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Election 2018 - Assembly candidates for Valley seat debate - Gun violence, sexual harassment addressed

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ENCINO >> With major policy differences still developing, leading candidates in a California Assembly race in the west San Fernando Valley offered a range of proposals on the timely issues of gun control and sexual harassment Tuesday in the first debate since the special-election ballot was set.

The nearly one-hour forum presented by the Encino and Sherman Oaks chambers of commerce featured five Democrats: attorney Jesse Gabriel, progressive activist Ankur Patel, Los Angeles City Council aide Tricia Robbins Kasson, West Hills Neighborhood Council President Daniel Brin and business and commercial broker Ray Bishop. Also invited but not attending were Republican Justin Clark, an 18-year-old Cal State Northridge student, and Democrat Jeff Bornstein, an electronics business owner. Former L.A. Councilman Dennis Zine is on the ballot but has quit the race.

The special election is April 3 to replace Matt Dababneh, the Democrat who resigned the Assembly District 45 seat in December after being accused of sexual misconduct. The seat represents an area that includes Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Canoga Park, Woodland Hills, West Hills, Winnetka, Northridge, Reseda, Tarzana, Encino and the Ventura County community of Bell Canyon.

Asked by moderator Jessica Levinson, a Loyola Law School professor, for proposals to reduce gun violence after the shooting deaths of 17 people at a Flor

ida high school last week, candidates identified a variety of causes. And they suggested general solutions, including better measures to keep firearms out of the hands of mentally ill people, more safety training and safe storage of guns in households, loosing restrictions on study of gun violence by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

Gabriel, the leading fundraiser in the race, said policymakers “need to do everything we can” about gun violence.

“When I went to school, I worried about pop quizzes, I worried about whether my clothes fit the right way, if I was going to fit in. It’s crazy to now that I’m going to have to worry that my kids are going to go to school, and I’ll have to worry about whether somebody’s going to commit a horrific act of gun violence,” Gabriel told a crowd of about 70 chambers of commerce members attending a $30-a-plate luncheon.

Robbins Kasson called for more gun buybacks, gun-purchase waiting periods and background checks, and limits on ammunition magazines.

Patel called for better steps to identify troubled youth and to keep guns from domestic violence perpetrators.

Asked how well the California Legislature is responding to the Sacramento sexual-misconduct scandal that has cost two lawmakers their job and forced two others to take leaves of absence, several candidates praised the leadership of Assemblywoman Laura Friedman, D-Glendale, author of one of the bills that help harassment victims. But only Robbins Kasson could say she has Friedman’s endorsement.

Gabriel said changing a culture of sexual harassment in the state Capitol requires electing a new generation of legislators.

Brin said victims need a safe place to report harassment. Bishop said government needs more moral leadership

than it’s getting from the Trump administration. Patel said justice is denied when misconduct is kept secret for years, as in the case of former Assemblyman Raul Bocanegra.

On other issues, all five Democrats called for trying to lessen the influence of money in elections, and praised California Attorney General Xavier Becerra’s lawsuits against the Trump administration.

In a “lightning round” of yes-no questions, only Patel opposed California’s gas-tax increase, and only Robbins Kasson expressed unfettered support for the bullet train.

One audience member, Justin Sandler, co-owner of 3 Cubed Studios, sounded disappointed by a lot of what he heard.

“It seems like they were telling us what they thought we want to hear,” Sandler said, “which is what a lot of politicians do.”

Amy Kalajian, founder of a home health care company, was happy to hear the discussion of gun-violence remedies.

“I wish, whatever they say, they make it happen,” Kalajian said.

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